



Android phones

It's safe to say that it hasn't been a smooth ride for Android in 2011. It has come under immense pressure from rival smartphone OSes. And its biggest rival has been the Apple iOS. Looking at how the two companies deal with the OS through its development and implementation stages, we can see how two differing approaches can still be hugely successful, within the same ecosystem.

While Apple likes to keep a tight control on hardware, software and services, Android's success has been with the numerous smartphones from multiple handset makers. Secondly, Android has been more liberal and welcoming towards applications for the Android Market, something Apple has very strict guidelines about.

While Android has generated superb numbers, there's a bit of a problem as well – the experience isn't as smooth and fluid as with an iOS device. This is where Apple's decision to keep a very close watch on the hardware has paid off. Google can't really do that, with multiple smartphone makers involved. Case in point being the UI skins (HTC Sense, MotoBlur etc.) that smartphone makers install over and above Android OS, in an attempt to differentiate their product in the market. While testing these devices, we've noticed often that these skins also tend to hamper performance – badly written code, poor memory optimisation and features that load the hardware are the primary causes. Which is exactly why Google has made it clear that no customisations of this proportion will be allowed with Android 3.0 and beyond.

However, while Apple has the iPhone, Google's Android comes on smartphones made by Samsung, HTC, LG and Motorola, to name a few. This allowed Android to be offered to the consumer at price points starting well under ₹10,000 and being a price-sensitive market, that's exactly what helped the numbers.

Zero1 Winner Samsung Galaxy SII

There's absolutely no doubt about it – this is *the* best Android smartphone you can buy at the moment. Excellent performance, a sleek form factor, impressive display and a surprisingly good battery life – what more can a smartphone offer?

Detailed review: <http://goo.gl/ChIek>



Samsung Galaxy SII

Price: ₹32,890

Worthy Mentions

LG Optimus 3D

If you pray to the Gods of 3D, how can you have a phone without 3D? Get this for an amazing multi-dimensional experience.

Detailed review: <http://goo.gl/IQ755>



LG Optimus 3D

Price: ₹37,000

HTC Sensation

True to HTC tradition, this is a phone that looks good and whose raw OS performance is excellent.

Detailed review: <http://goo.gl/fd8LM>

HTC ChaCha

Offers the best of both worlds, with a touchscreen and QWERTY. For the social networking fans.

Detailed review: <http://goo.gl/4Cj8r>



HTC Sensation

Price: ₹29,600



HTC ChaCha

Price: ₹17,990

TouchWiz 4.0

The Galaxy S II boasts of Samsung's latest UI, called the TouchWiz 4.0. It completely replaces the default Android UI to provide a unique experience and features slick animations and transitions.